though the numbers were comparatively high. The estimates ranged from fifty to a hundred bunkers at each company location. Inter-connected through ‘traffic’ trenches, it was thought that each bunker could hold three to five men. It was estimated that the structures were convenient to live and fight from, each bunker having one to three firing holes that were visible. Most of these opened towards the front, where the range of vision and field of fire was narrow while the dead angle of firing (blind side) was large. Camouflage and concealment of the bunkers was reportedly very good, some of the structures not being easy to locate. 7 Brigade had more or less completed the defensive structures required for each stronghold in twenty days. One of the OPs (observation posts) was reporting the construction of a 40-metre communication trench that had come up in a single night. The Chinese commanders also noted that in the organization of firepower, the Indians seemingly had a tendency to pay special attention to the front side, *ignoring the rear altogether.*

On 18 October, operational orders were issued from the Forward HQ of the Tibet Military Command to all Chinese units. The Chinese higher command was determined that the first blow should be a decisive one that annihilated the Indian troops of 7 Brigade. The Chinese commanders were not only fully updated on the Indian army units that were facing them; they also had a fair idea of the military traditions and fighting capabilities of the Indians. Field commanders had been cautioned that they were up against elite Indian troops, and though the Chinese army should strategically despise the enemy, tactically they needed to be taken seriously. Tibetan Command also cautioned that the Chinese troops must be prepared to fight a long, hard and adverse battle, and, if necessary, prepare to fight a second and a third battle.

Based on the instructions that they ‘must win the first war’, Forward HQ of the Tibet Military Command had to consider ‘how big the mouth should be opened’. If the mouth was opened large, then it would not be possible to completely annihilate the Indian forces; if it was opened too small, the Indians could pull themselves out of the tactically unsound position they were in on the ‘Kejie Lang River Valley (Nam Ka Chu)’, regroup and put up a tough fight. Zang Zi 419 now had the option of three combat tactics available to them.

First, carry out a frontal attack on the Indian positions, with subsequent rolling attacks towards the left and right. This method would be akin to